

INTRODUCTION

It all starts with a simple concept: You want your dog to have a yard.

As you picture little Fido rolling around in green grass with ample space to roam, your thoughts wander further, and the simple concept turns into a dream. Maybe you don't want a roommate or to share walls with anyone else. Your upstairs neighbors stomp around like clumsy baby elephants. You want to paint the bedroom walls lime green and listen to Nickelback without fear of being overheard. Your landlord is, quite frankly, a bridge troll. You're throwing your money away on renting this place, anyway.

Suddenly, you're thinking of buying a house.

It's a no-brainer, right? Tax breaks! Long-term appreciation! Fixing up the outdated kitchen and adding hundreds of thousands of dollars in value! Just think of the possibilities!

Though the potential benefits are endless, we're here to give you some bad news—the potential problems are also endless. On the other end of the spectrum, you have broken toilets, wire fraud, and financial disaster that could spiral into endless debt and the possibility of foreclosure.

No pressure.

If you're reading this book, you are probably about to make what is the most significant financial decision of your life so far. Let's say that again: Buying a home is, first and foremost, a *financial decision*. Forget about your forbidden love of Nickelback, and forget all the people who have shouted from the rooftops that renting an apartment is worse than shoving all your cash down the garbage disposal (and then needing to call your landlord to fix your sink).

You've seen the workings of this financial decision before. Countless people buy their dream home right out of the gate—the huge, beautiful